THE PRISMATIC METHOD

Applied Analysis

Brexit as a Case Study in Interpretive Divergence

Produced using the method described in

Silent Transitions: How Interpretive Grammars Process the Same World into Different Truths

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STEP 0: PRE-ANALYSIS REFLEXIVE DECLARATION

Home grammar. My likely home grammar for this topic is what I will define below as the Economic-Rationalist Grammar. This is an artefact of my analytical training: when confronted with a complex political phenomenon, my default processing architecture reaches first for measurable economic indicators, treats opportunity-cost reasoning as the most reliable causal chain, and is disposed to read identity-based claims as epiphenomenal expressions of material conditions. I am aware that this orientation was significantly reinforced by the post-referendum dominance of economic framing in institutional and academic analysis, which made economic-rationalist closure feel like "objectivity" rather than a grammar choice.

Hardest grammar. The grammar I expect to find most difficult to operate faithfully is the Sovereignty-Democratic Grammar. This difficulty is not a matter of disagreement with its conclusions—disagreement is compatible with faithful operation—but rather a structural challenge: its primary analytical variable (democratic self-determination) operates at a level of abstraction that my default processing finds difficult to weight as causally fundamental. I am predisposed to re-translate sovereignty claims into material or institutional terms, which would collapse the grammar rather than operate it. I will need to resist that translation impulse throughout Section IV.

Likely blind spots. From my position I am most likely to under-weight signals that operate in the register of cultural meaning-making, collective identity formation, and affective attachment to political community. I am also likely to miss the degree to which "economic" signals are themselves grammar-dependent constructs—GDP trajectory, for instance, is not a raw observation but an output of a measurement grammar with its own signal-selection rules and exclusions. My temporal orientation is primarily causal-historical with a secondary prescriptive lean. I am inclined to ask "what caused this?" and then "what should be done?", and less inclined to ask "what does this mean?"—which is the characteristic question of the hermeneutic orientation.

I. OBSERVATION FIELD DECLARATION

Phenomenon

The phenomenon under analysis is the United Kingdom's decision to withdraw from the European Union and the consequences of that withdrawal. The temporal frame spans from the referendum of 23 June 2016 through March 2026, encompassing the campaign period, the Article 50 process (2017–2020), the implementation of the Trade and Cooperation Agreement, and the accumulating post-transition effects across economic, institutional, and cultural domains. The geographic scope is primarily the United Kingdom, with necessary reference to the EU-27 as counterparty, and to international observation where it constitutes a distinct interpretive community.

Why Interpretive Divergence Occurs

Brexit generates acute interpretive divergence for several structural reasons. First, the phenomenon is multi-dimensional: it simultaneously involves economic policy, constitutional arrangements, immigration systems, regulatory architecture, geopolitical positioning, and national identity. No single analytical framework can process all these dimensions with equal fidelity, which means every grammar must select, and every selection creates a different object of analysis. Second, the referendum itself was binary—Leave or Remain—but the phenomenon it produced is continuous and multi-causal, which means the same post-referendum data can be processed as evidence for radically different causal stories. Third, the temporal structure is such that many consequences are slow-moving and entangled with confounding variables (COVID-19, the global energy crisis, the Ukraine conflict, domestic fiscal policy), making clean causal attribution grammar-dependent. Fourth, Brexit operates as an identity marker in British political culture, which means interpretive positions carry affective and social stakes beyond their analytical content. The grammars are not merely analytical tools; they are membership cards.

Signal Contestation Level

High. Several core signals—GDP counterfactual estimates, the net fiscal contribution to the EU, the economic effects of immigration, and the democratic legitimacy of the referendum itself—are contested not merely in their interpretation but in their composition. What counts as a valid GDP counterfactual, for instance, depends on modelling assumptions that are themselves grammar-dependent. The contestation extends to second-order signals: whether opinion polling measures genuine preference or constructed sentiment, whether trade volume changes reflect Brexit effects or global disruption, and whether regulatory divergence should be measured by formal difference or practical impact.

Major Interpretive Communities

The principal interpretive communities map roughly onto the three grammars specified below: an economic-rationalist community centred in academic economics, the Treasury, the Bank of England, and much of the broadsheet press; a sovereignty-democratic community distributed across Leave-supporting media, substantial portions of the Conservative Party and Reform UK, and a significant fraction of the electorate; and a cultural-identity

community that operates in both progressive and conservative registers, processing Brexit primarily as a meaning-making event concerning national identity, cultural belonging, and the affective structure of political community. There are also smaller, more specialist interpretive communities—legal-constitutionalist, geopolitical-strategic—which I note but do not elevate to full grammar status, judging them to be sub-grammars of the three principal frameworks.

II. SIGNAL SET

Core Signals

S1: Referendum result (51.9%–48.1%). Source: Electoral Commission. Type: Quantitative, definitive. Ambiguity lies not in the number but in what it authorises: a mandate for hard Brexit, soft Brexit, or merely an instruction to leave?

S2: GDP trajectory (2016–2026). Source: ONS, OBR, IMF. Type: Quantitative, contested. Counterfactual dependency: what would GDP have been absent Brexit? Estimates range from 1.5% to 5.5% GDP loss by 2026, depending on model assumptions.

S3: UK–EU goods trade volumes. Source: HMRC, Eurostat. Type: Quantitative. Trade volumes fell sharply in early 2021, partially recovered, but remain structurally below pre-referendum trend. Confounded by COVID-19 effects.

S4: UK–Rest of World trade volumes. Source: HMRC, DIT. Type: Quantitative. New FTAs (Australia, New Zealand, CPTPP accession) have not offset EU trade reduction in volume terms, though strategic value is contested.

S5: Net migration figures. Source: ONS. Type: Quantitative, politically charged. Post-Brexit net migration rose sharply (745,000 in 2022, subsequently revised and declining), shifting from EU to non-EU sources. Signals processed in opposite directions by different grammars.

S6: Northern Ireland Protocol / Windsor Framework. Source: UK Government, EU Commission. Type: Institutional, legal. A constitutional novelty: regulatory alignment with the EU within UK territory. Processed as pragmatic compromise or sovereignty violation.

S7: Scottish independence polling. Source: Various polling firms. Type: Quantitative, volatile. Support fluctuated between 45–55% post-Brexit, remaining persistently elevated relative to pre-referendum baselines but not achieving sustained majority.

S8: Institutional trust indicators. Source: British Social Attitudes, Edelman. Type: Survey-based, trend data. Trust in Parliament, media, and expert institutions has not recovered to pre-2016 levels. Causal attribution is grammar-dependent.

S9: Manufacturing sector performance. Source: ONS, Make UK. Type: Quantitative. Manufacturing output has underperformed the pre-referendum trend, with specific subsectors (automotive, chemicals) citing regulatory and customs barriers.

S10: Services sector and financial services. Source: ONS, TheCityUK. Type: Quantitative, institutional. Financial services lost passporting rights; some activity relocated. The scale of relocation is contested (modest vs. significant).

S11: Regulatory divergence indicators. Source: UK in a Changing Europe. Type: Qualitative/quantitative hybrid. Divergence has been slower and more selective than either advocates or critics predicted. Areas of divergence: gene editing, data protection, AI regulation, subsidy control.

S12: Cultural and identity polling. Source: British Social Attitudes, NatCen. Type: Survey-based. Leave/Remain identity has proven more durable than traditional party identification. "Brexiteer" and "Remainer" function as persistent identity markers.

S13: Investment flows (FDI). Source: UNCTAD, fDi Markets. Type: Quantitative. FDI inflows to the UK fell relative to comparator economies post-referendum. Attribution is contested between Brexit effects and global trends.

S14: Labour market indicators. Source: ONS, Migration Advisory Committee. Type: Quantitative. Labour shortages in specific sectors (agriculture, hospitality, logistics, social care) coincided with the end of free movement. Partially addressed by visa schemes.

Counter-Signals

CS1: UK tech sector growth. The UK technology sector has continued to attract significant venture capital investment and has grown robustly through the post-Brexit period. This complicates the narrative of straightforward economic decline, though it may reflect sector-specific dynamics rather than Brexit effects.

CS2: EU institutional challenges. The EU itself has faced significant difficulties—rule-of-law crises in Hungary and Poland, the energy crisis, the failure of the EU Constitution, stalled integration in defence policy—which complicate narratives that treat EU membership as an unambiguous good.

CS3: Pandemic performance comparisons. The UK's rapid COVID-19 vaccine procurement and rollout was partially attributed to regulatory independence. This is a counter-signal to the Economic-Rationalist Grammar and a confirmation signal for the Sovereignty-Democratic Grammar, illustrating grammar-dependent processing of the same event.

CS4: Absence of predicted catastrophe. Several dire predictions made during the referendum campaign (immediate recession, dramatic unemployment increase, emergency budget) did not materialise. This counter-signal is processed differently depending on temporal framing: short-term non-catastrophe versus long-term structural drag.

CS5: Electoral persistence. In polling, a majority of voters continue to report that Brexit was the "wrong decision," yet no major party campaigns on rejoin. This gap between expressed opinion and political supply complicates all three grammars.

Contested Signals

CnS1: The £350 million figure. The Leave campaign's claim regarding weekly EU contributions is processed as: (a) a lie that delegitimises the referendum result (Economic-Rationalist), (b) a broadly correct statement about gross contributions that opponents deflect from (Sovereignty-Democratic), or (c) an irrelevant accounting dispute that obscures the real cultural dynamics at play (Cultural-Identity).

CnS2: Immigration net benefit calculations. Whether EU immigration produced a net fiscal benefit depends on the accounting methodology employed (static vs. dynamic, time horizon, inclusion of capital costs). Each grammar selects the methodology that aligns with its causal architecture.

CnS3: Sovereignty as measurable or ineffable. Whether "sovereignty" constitutes a signal at all, or merely a rhetorical gesture, is itself grammar-dependent. For the Sovereignty-Democratic Grammar it is the primary signal. For the Economic-Rationalist Grammar it is at best a preference parameter, at worst a category error.

III. GRAMMAR SPECIFICATIONS

I specify three grammars. The choice of three rather than two or four reflects a judgment that British and international Brexit discourse organises around three genuinely distinct processing architectures. A fourth grammar—a geopolitical-strategic framework processing Brexit through great-power competition and alliance structures—was considered and rejected on the grounds that it typically operates as a sub-grammar of either the Economic-Rationalist or Sovereignty-Democratic framework rather than possessing an independent causal architecture. I flag, however, a potentially emergent grammar at the end of this section.

Grammar A: The Economic-Rationalist Grammar

Required Parameters

1. Primary analytical variable: Economic welfare, measured in aggregate output, trade flows, investment, and productivity. The grammar treats material prosperity as the causally fundamental variable from which other outcomes (institutional stability, social cohesion, geopolitical influence) derive.

2. Signal selection rules: Admits quantifiable economic indicators, model-based counterfactuals, and expert institutional assessments (OBR, IMF, Bank of England). Admits survey data only when it concerns economic expectations or consumer confidence. Treats identity and cultural signals as secondary or epiphenomenal.

3. Weighting priority: GDP and trade data are primary. Investment flows and productivity indicators are secondary. Labour market data is tertiary. Cultural indicators receive negligible weight.

4. Causal chain type: Counterfactual-comparative. The grammar constructs explanations by comparing observed outcomes to a modelled counterfactual (UK-had-it-remained). Causal claims are expressed as difference-in-difference estimates. The chain is: policy change → friction/barrier → reduced economic activity → lower welfare.

5. Admissible closure: Closure must be expressed as a cost-benefit assessment. The range runs from "modest net economic cost" to "significant and ongoing economic damage." The grammar cannot produce a closure of "net economic benefit from Brexit" without abandoning its own modelling conventions. Closure of "economically neutral but democratically justified" is also outside the grammar's range: it would require admitting a non-economic primary variable.

Recommended Parameters

6. Excluded signals: Sovereignty as an intrinsic good; cultural belonging as a causal variable; democratic mandates as analytically decisive; affective responses to immigration that are not reducible to labour-market effects.

7. Characteristic vocabulary: "Gravity model," "trade friction," "non-tariff barriers," "GDP hit," "counterfactual," "self-harm," "evidence-based," "experts," "single market access," "productivity puzzle."

8. Temporal orientation: Primarily prescriptive (forward-looking): what should be done to mitigate damage? Secondarily causal-historical: what caused the damage?

9. Temporal formation: This grammar's closure crystallised rapidly during the referendum campaign (Treasury forecasts, IMF warnings) and has been reinforced post-referendum. Post-formation evidence (trade data, investment data) has been processed overwhelmingly as confirmation. The vaccine counter-signal was processed as damage-control: acknowledged briefly, then recontextualised as an exception within a broader pattern of harm.

Grammar Boundary

Grammar A would transform into Grammar B if it accepted democratic self-determination as a causally fundamental variable not reducible to economic preference aggregation. It would transform into Grammar C if it accepted cultural identity as a primary analytical variable rather than an epiphenomenon of material conditions.

Source tradition: Institutional economics; trade theory (Ricardian comparative advantage, gravity models); welfare economics; the epistemic culture of the Treasury and central banking.

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Grammar B: The Sovereignty-Democratic Grammar

Required Parameters

1. Primary analytical variable: Democratic self-governance, understood as the capacity of a national polity to make, amend, and repeal its own laws through accountable institutions. Sovereignty is not merely instrumental (a means to better policy) but constitutive (a condition for legitimate governance).

2. Signal selection rules: Admits institutional indicators (regulatory independence, judicial supremacy, border control, legislative capacity), democratic legitimacy indicators (referendum results, parliamentary sovereignty), and sovereignty-relevant economic data (capacity to set independent trade, industrial, and immigration policy). Admits economic data selectively: as evidence of what independent policy can achieve, or as context for policy choices, but not as the primary metric of success.

3. Weighting priority: The referendum mandate is primary. Regulatory and legal independence indicators are secondary. Economic data is tertiary and contextual. Cultural identity signals are admitted but subordinated to the democratic-procedural framework.

4. Causal chain type: Constitutional-procedural. The grammar constructs explanations through democratic legitimacy chains: the people voted → the instruction was implemented → self-governance was restored → policy autonomy now enables tailored national responses. Where economic costs are acknowledged, they are framed as the price of self-governance, analogous to the costs of national defence.

5. Admissible closure: Closure ranges from "democratic mandate fulfilled, sovereignty restored, benefits emerging" to "democratic mandate fulfilled, sovereignty restored, benefits yet to be fully realised due to implementation failures." The grammar cannot produce a

closure of "Brexit was a mistake" without abandoning the primacy of the democratic mandate. It can produce "Brexit was implemented badly" because this locates failure in execution, not principle.

Recommended Parameters

6. Excluded signals: Counterfactual economic models that assume continued membership as the correct baseline; expert consensus when it functions as an authority claim rather than evidence; cultural-identity explanations that reduce Leave voters to irrational affect.

7. Characteristic vocabulary: "Taking back control," "democratic mandate," "self-governing nation," "sovereignty," "accountability," "Global Britain," "independent trade policy," "regulatory freedom," "will of the people," "project fear."

8. Temporal orientation: Forward-looking and prescriptive: what can the UK now do with its restored sovereignty? Secondarily hermeneutic: what does Brexit mean for the national story?

9. Temporal formation: The grammar's current form crystallised during the 2016 campaign but draws on a much longer Eurosceptic tradition (Bruges speech, Maastricht rebellion, UKIP's twenty-year campaign). Post-formation, evidence has been processed primarily as confirmation (regulatory independence achieved, new trade deals signed) or as externalisation (economic underperformance attributed to COVID, global disruption, or government incompetence rather than to Brexit itself).

Grammar Boundary

Grammar B would transform into Grammar A if it accepted that economic welfare is the primary metric by which the sovereignty decision should be judged—that is, if sovereignty's value became entirely instrumental. It would transform into Grammar C if democratic procedure became less important than the cultural-identity content that the procedure was meant to protect.

Source tradition: Parliamentary sovereignty doctrine; Diceyan constitutionalism; Westphalian state theory; the Eurosceptic intellectual tradition (from Enoch Powell through Daniel Hannan); democratic theory emphasising majoritarian mandates.

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Grammar C: The Cultural-Identity Grammar

Required Parameters

1. Primary analytical variable: Cultural identity, meaning-making, and the affective structure of political community. The grammar treats Brexit as primarily an identity event: an expression of who "we" are, a statement about belonging, place, change, and loss. Economic and sovereignty claims are understood as vehicles for deeper identity commitments.

2. Signal selection rules: Admits cultural and identity polling, demographic correlations (age, education, geography, social class as proxies for identity position), media discourse analysis, affective indicators (feelings of being "left behind," nostalgia, cosmopolitan vs.

communitarian orientations). Admits economic and institutional signals only as they illuminate identity dynamics.

3. Weighting priority: Identity polling and demographic correlations are primary. Media discourse and narrative framing are secondary. Economic data is tertiary and processed as identity-relevant only (e.g., regional economic inequality as a proxy for felt marginalisation).

4. Causal chain type: Hermeneutic-structural. The grammar does not primarily ask "what caused Brexit?" in a mechanistic sense but "what does Brexit express?" and "what structures of feeling produced it?" Causal claims, where made, follow the form: structural change (deindustrialisation, globalisation, demographic shift) → identity disruption → affective mobilisation → political expression through the referendum.

5. Admissible closure: Closure ranges from "Brexit was an identity rupture expressing deep structural divisions in British society that remain unresolved" to "Brexit was a cultural realignment that has produced a new, if unstable, settlement of national identity." The grammar can produce closures of tragedy, irony, or ambivalence. It cannot easily produce a closure of simple success or simple failure, because its analytical architecture is oriented toward meaning rather than outcome.

Recommended Parameters

6. Excluded signals: Aggregate economic indicators treated as decisive in their own right; constitutional-legal analysis abstracted from cultural context; rational-choice models of voter behaviour that treat preferences as given rather than culturally constituted.

7. Characteristic vocabulary: "Left behind," "anywheres and somewheres," "cultural backlash," "nostalgia," "identity politics," "populism," "structure of feeling," "affective polarisation," "cosmopolitan vs. communitarian," "values divide."

8. Temporal orientation: Primarily hermeneutic (lateral): what does this mean? Secondarily causal-historical: what deep structures produced this meaning?

9. Temporal formation: This grammar crystallised in the immediate aftermath of the referendum, drawing on pre-existing academic work (Goodhart's "Anywhere/Somewhere" framework, Inglehart's post-materialist thesis, Hochschild's work on the "deep story"). Post-formation, evidence has been processed as confirmation of deep division (the persistence of Leave/Remain identity) or as complication (the failure of identity to translate straightforwardly into party realignment). The 2024 Labour election victory was processed ambivalently: as evidence that the identity divide could be partially cross-cut by other factors, but not resolved.

Grammar Boundary

Grammar C would transform into Grammar A if it accepted that identity claims are epiphenomenal to material conditions—that "left behind" is really just "economically disadvantaged" and requires no independent cultural analysis. It would transform into Grammar B if it accepted that the democratic mandate, rather than the identity content it expressed, is the analytically decisive variable.

Source tradition: Cultural studies; political sociology (Lipset's cleavage theory, updated); post-materialist value theory (Inglehart); the "left behind" literature; Gramscian cultural hegemony analysis; affect theory in political science.

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Note on a Potentially Emergent Grammar

I flag a grammar that may be crystallising in the 2024–2026 period, which I tentatively label the Post-Brexit Pragmatic Grammar. This framework is distinguished by its refusal of the Leave/Remain binary, its treatment of Brexit as a settled institutional fact rather than an ongoing argument, and its forward-looking orientation toward specific regulatory and trade policy choices rather than the constitutional question. Its primary analytical variable would be institutional adaptability. It is visible in some policy think-tank output, in the Starmer government's approach to EU relations, and in business community discourse. I do not elevate it to full grammar status because it has not yet developed a stable causal architecture or a clear closure range—it is still operating parasitically on elements of Grammars A and B. But it may represent a genuinely new processing framework rather than a hybrid of existing ones.

IV. SIGNAL PROCESSING

Grammar A Processing: The Economic-Rationalist Account

The referendum result (S1) is admitted by this grammar but processed as a democratic input to policy, not as an analytically decisive fact. The 52–48 margin is narrow, the binary format concealed profound disagreements about what "Leave" meant, and the campaign was compromised by misinformation (the contested £350 million claim, CnS1, is processed here as a paradigmatic example of epistemic failure in democratic deliberation). The grammar registers the result but immediately moves to ask: what are the economic consequences of the policy this result produced?

GDP trajectory (S2) is the grammar's primary signal and its most powerful instrument. By 2026, the consensus range of counterfactual GDP estimates places the UK economy between 2% and 4% smaller than it would have been absent Brexit, with the OBR's central estimate around 4%. This is processed as a large and ongoing cost, roughly equivalent to losing the output of a mid-sized city. The grammar acknowledges methodological contestation around these estimates (counter-signal: the uncertainty bands are wide, and counterfactuals are not observations), but notes that the range of credible estimates runs from "modest cost" to "large cost," with no credible model producing "net benefit." The absence of predicted catastrophe (CS4) is processed as a question of trajectory rather than level: the UK did not fall off a cliff, but it has diverged from its pre-referendum growth path, and this divergence compounds.

Trade data (S3, S4) reinforces the GDP story. UK–EU goods trade has been structurally disrupted by the introduction of customs checks, rules of origin requirements, and regulatory barriers. The grammar notes that the UK's new trade agreements with Australia, New Zealand, and the CPTPP accession (S4) are admitted as signals but weighted as marginal: the gravity model predicts that trade with geographically proximate, economically similar partners will always dominate, and no plausible set of distant FTAs can compensate for increased friction with a market that accounts for approximately 42% of UK exports. The grammar processes the new FTAs as evidence of activity, not of compensation.

Investment data (S13) is processed as strongly confirmatory. FDI inflows have declined relative to comparator economies, and business investment has underperformed, with survey evidence consistently citing regulatory uncertainty and market access concerns as factors. The tech sector counter-signal (CS1) is admitted but processed as sector-specific: technology investment is relatively friction-insensitive because the product is digital and the talent pool is global. It does not generalise to goods-producing or regulated-services sectors.

The labour market signals (S5, S14) present an internal complexity. Net migration rose sharply after Brexit, confounding the expectation that ending free movement would reduce immigration. The grammar processes this as evidence that the economic demand for labour was the underlying driver, and that the points-based system merely redirected flows rather than reducing them—at higher administrative cost and with worse matching to employer needs. Labour shortages in specific sectors (S14) are processed as a direct cost of leaving the single market for labour. However, the grammar must contend with the counter-signal that non-EU migration rose partly due to government policy choices (the post-study work visa, the Ukraine and Hong Kong schemes), which are not mechanically attributable to Brexit.

The Northern Ireland Protocol/Windsor Framework (S6) is processed as a revealing case study in the economic costs of sovereignty choices: the UK's insistence on leaving the customs union and single market made a border somewhere in the Irish Sea/land border area inevitable, and the resulting arrangements impose administrative costs on UK internal trade. Financial services (S10) are processed as a sector where the loss of passporting rights has produced real, if less dramatic than feared, relocation of activity and revenue to EU financial centres.

Regulatory divergence (S11) is processed ambivalently. The grammar expected divergence to impose costs through regulatory duplication and market fragmentation, and in some areas this has occurred. But the counter-signal is that divergence has been slower than expected, partly because businesses lobbied against it and partly because regulators recognised the costs. The vaccine rollout counter-signal (CS3) is acknowledged as a genuine case of beneficial regulatory independence, but processed as an exception: it required emergency conditions and political will that do not characterise normal regulatory divergence.

Closure: Brexit has imposed a significant and ongoing economic cost on the United Kingdom. The cost is not catastrophic but is substantial, cumulative, and structural rather than cyclical. It manifests as reduced trade, lower investment, diminished productivity growth, and a smaller economy than the counterfactual. The cost is unlikely to reverse without a fundamental change in the UK's relationship with the EU single market. The economic case for Brexit has not been made by the evidence. This closure is an architectural product of the grammar's primary variable (economic welfare), its signal selection (quantitative, model-based), and its causal chain (counterfactual-comparative). It is a robust closure within the grammar but it is not a view from nowhere.

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Grammar B Processing: The Sovereignty-Democratic Account

The referendum result (S1) is the foundational signal—not merely an input but the architecturally decisive fact. 17.4 million people voted to leave the European Union. This is processed as the largest democratic mandate in British history, and the grammar treats subsequent analysis as operating within the authority of that mandate, not above it. The narrow margin is acknowledged but processed through democratic theory: in a binary referendum, a majority is a majority; no democratic theory recognises a supermajority requirement retroactively imposed. The contested £350 million figure (CnS1) is processed as a political claim in the normal register of campaign rhetoric, no more misleading than Remain's predictions of immediate recession, and in any case not the primary reason people voted Leave.

The grammar's primary processing operation is to assess the sovereignty dividend. Regulatory independence (S11) is the key signal: the UK has recovered the legal capacity to set its own regulations, conduct its own trade negotiations, control its own borders, and legislate without reference to EU law or the European Court of Justice. That this capacity has been exercised cautiously is not evidence against its value; it is evidence of responsible governance. The grammar processes the slow pace of divergence as a feature, not a bug: the point was to have the choice, not to diverge for divergence's sake. Where divergence has occurred—gene editing regulation, AI governance, subsidy control, data protection—it is processed as proof of concept.

The vaccine rollout (CS3) is processed as a paradigmatic confirmation signal: a case where regulatory independence, combined with political will, produced a tangible, life-saving advantage that would not have been available within the EU's joint procurement and regulatory framework. The grammar notes that EU member states subsequently acknowledged the slowness of their own process. This single case does not need to carry the entire weight of the sovereignty argument, but it is processed as a vivid demonstration of what independent capacity can achieve.

Trade policy independence (S4) is processed as a structural achievement. The UK has signed trade agreements with Australia, New Zealand, Japan, and acceded to the CPTPP—a transpacific partnership that positions the UK in the fastest-growing economic region. The grammar acknowledges that these agreements have not yet produced large trade volumes (the Economic-Rationalist Grammar's objection), but processes this as a temporal argument: the strategic value of diversified trade relationships is a long-term asset, and judging them by short-term volume is the wrong metric. The grammar's temporal orientation is forward-looking: the benefits of sovereignty compound over decades, not quarters.

GDP counterfactual estimates (S2) are admitted but contested. The grammar challenges the methodology: counterfactual models assume that the pre-referendum trend would have continued absent Brexit, which is itself an assumption that ignores the UK's pre-existing structural challenges (low productivity, regional inequality, infrastructure deficits) that existed within the EU and were not being addressed by membership. The grammar also notes the confounding variables (COVID, Ukraine, energy crisis) that make clean attribution impossible, and processes the Economic-Rationalist Grammar's confidence in its counterfactuals as an example of model-dependent certainty masquerading as empirical fact.

Immigration data (S5) presents a complex signal. Net migration rose after Brexit, which the grammar must process. It does so in two moves: first, by noting that the composition of migration shifted from uncontrolled EU free movement to a points-based system that admits people based on skills and salary thresholds—a qualitative change in sovereign control even if the quantitative flow increased. Second, by attributing the high numbers to specific government policy choices (the post-COVID recovery visa, the Hong Kong BN(O) scheme) that could be revised, demonstrating that the system is responsive to democratic pressure in ways that free movement was not. The high numbers are processed not as a failure of Brexit but as a policy choice made possible by Brexit: the point was to have the lever, not necessarily to pull it in one direction.

The Northern Ireland Protocol (S6) is processed as a genuine difficulty—the grammar does not deny this—but one created by EU intransigence during negotiations and by the unique circumstances of the Irish border. The Windsor Framework is processed as a pragmatic resolution that preserves the UK's essential sovereignty while managing a specific geographic anomaly. Scottish independence polling (S7) is processed as a separate constitutional question that predates Brexit and whose dynamics are driven by Scottish domestic politics rather than by Brexit itself.

Institutional trust (S8) is processed through a counter-narrative: trust in institutions was already declining before the referendum, partly because those institutions were perceived as unresponsive to democratic sentiment—a perception that the Brexit vote itself expressed. The decline in trust is processed not as a consequence of Brexit but as a pre-existing

condition that Brexit was a symptom of, and potentially a treatment for, insofar as it demonstrated that democratic action could override institutional preferences.

Closure: The democratic mandate of the referendum has been fulfilled. The United Kingdom has recovered the constitutional essentials of self-governance: legislative supremacy, regulatory independence, border control, and an independent trade policy. The economic costs, while not negligible, are within the normal range of adjustment costs associated with major institutional change, are confounded by external shocks, and are offset by long-term strategic gains in flexibility and diversification that are not yet fully visible. The benefits of sovereignty are structural and cumulative; they should not be judged by short-term economic metrics designed within a framework that assumes EU membership as the correct baseline. Implementation has been imperfect, but the principle is vindicated. This closure is an architectural product of the grammar's primary variable (democratic self-governance), its weighting (mandate over metrics), and its temporal orientation (long-term and forward-looking).

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Grammar C Processing: The Cultural-Identity Account

The referendum result (S1) is processed not primarily as a number but as an event—a rupture in the surface of British political life that made visible a set of deep cultural divisions previously submerged beneath the routines of party politics. The 52–48 split maps, with strong but imperfect correlation, onto a set of demographic and identity cleavages: age (the young voted Remain, the old voted Leave), education (degree-holders voted Remain, non-graduates voted Leave), geography (cities voted Remain, towns and rural areas voted Leave), and values orientation (cosmopolitan versus communitarian, open versus closed, liberal versus authoritarian on social questions). The grammar reads these correlations not as sociological trivia but as the primary signal: Brexit was an identity election in which the operative question was not "what is the optimal trade arrangement?" or even "who should make our laws?" but "who are we?"

The grammar processes the cultural-identity polling data (S12) as its most important ongoing signal. The finding that Leave/Remain identity has proven more durable than traditional party identification—more predictive of attitudes on a wide range of issues, from immigration to climate change to trust in institutions—is processed as evidence that the referendum did not merely register a pre-existing preference but created a new identity structure. People did not just vote; they became Leavers and Remainers, and these identities now organise perception, shape social networks, and filter information. This is, for Grammar C, the most consequential outcome of the referendum: not the trade deal or the regulatory arrangement but the identity architecture it installed.

Economic signals (S2, S3, S4, S13) are admitted but reprocessed. GDP trajectory is not denied but is read through an identity lens: the fact that economic data has not settled the argument—that ten years of evidence have not produced convergence—is itself the important signal. If Brexit were primarily an economic question, evidence would produce agreement. The fact that it does not is evidence that it is not primarily an economic question. The grammar reads the persistence of the economic debate not as a failure of analysis but as a symptom of identity investment: people process economic data through their identity position, not the other way round.

Immigration (S5) is the grammar's richest signal field. The grammar reads immigration not primarily through labour-market economics or sovereignty theory but through the phenomenology of place, change, and belonging. The Leave vote correlated not with immigration levels but with the rate of change in immigration: communities that experienced rapid demographic transformation were more likely to vote Leave, even when (or especially when) the transformation brought measurable economic benefits. This is processed as evidence that the operative concern was not economic but existential: a feeling that the familiar social world was changing beyond recognition, and that no one had asked permission. The grammar reads this not as xenophobia (a charge it considers reductive) but as an expression of a legitimate human need for continuity, recognition, and a sense of control over the conditions of one's communal life.

However—and here the grammar integrates its own counter-signal—the cultural-identity framework must also account for the identities on the other side. Remainers also experienced the referendum as an identity event: as a rejection of the cosmopolitan, European, open society they understood themselves to inhabit. The grief, anger, and disbelief expressed by Remain voters in the aftermath was not proportionate to a policy disagreement; it was proportionate to an identity wound. The grammar must process both sides as identity claims, which complicates any narrative that treats one side as identity-driven and the other as rational. Both sides were engaged in meaning-making; they simply made different meanings.

The persistence of division—the failure of the country to "move on" despite a decade of post-referendum history—is processed as the grammar's strongest confirmatory signal. If Brexit were a policy question, the passage of time and the accumulation of evidence would produce convergence. That it has not—that Leave and Remain identities remain structurally intact in 2026, organising perception and social life—is processed as proof that the phenomenon is irreducibly cultural. The grammar notes the irony: Brexit was supposed to settle a question, but it created a new and more fundamental question about who the British are to each other.

The Northern Ireland situation (S6) is processed as a concentrated expression of the identity dynamics at play across the UK: a place where questions of sovereignty, economics, and regulation are inextricable from questions of communal identity, belonging, and the meaning of borders. The Scottish question (S7) is similarly processed: Scottish independence polling is not primarily about fiscal transfers or EU market access but about national identity and the felt legitimacy of the UK as a shared political community after Brexit disrupted the constitutional settlement.

Institutional trust (S8) is processed as reflecting a crisis of narrative authority: the institutions that lost trust were those that claimed to speak from a position above identity—experts, economists, the BBC, the civil service—and the trust collapse is read as the revenge of the particular against the universal, of lived experience against modelled prediction.

Closure: Brexit was and remains primarily a cultural-identity event. It expressed a deep structural division in British society between cosmopolitan and communitarian orientations, between those who experience globalisation as opportunity and those who experience it as loss, between those whose identity is enhanced by openness and those whose identity depends on continuity. The referendum did not resolve this division; it rendered it visible,

named it, and gave it a political structure. The economic and sovereignty debates are real but secondary: they are the language in which identity claims are made. The most consequential legacy of Brexit is not the trade deal or the regulatory framework but the identity architecture it installed in British political culture—an architecture that shows no sign of dissolution and that will shape political life for a generation. This closure is an architectural product of the grammar's primary variable (cultural identity), its hermeneutic causal chain, and its orientation toward meaning rather than outcome.

V. CLOSURE COMPARISON

Closure Content

Grammar A closes on cost: Brexit is an ongoing economic wound whose severity is debated within bounds but whose existence is not in doubt. Grammar B closes on fulfilment: the democratic mandate has been executed and sovereignty restored, creating structural conditions for long-term advantage. Grammar C closes on meaning: Brexit is an identity rupture whose economic and constitutional dimensions are epiphenomenal to a deeper cultural division. These are not three answers to the same question; they are three answers to three different questions—What did it cost? Was it legitimate? What does it mean?—that happen to share a referent.

Signal Divergence

The most dramatic signal divergence occurs around GDP counterfactuals (S2), where Grammar A treats these as the decisive evidence, Grammar B treats them as methodologically suspect, and Grammar C treats them as beside the point. Immigration data (S5) is the signal most transformed by grammar rotation: from labour-market inefficiency (A) to sovereign control demonstrated (B) to phenomenology of place and belonging (C). Regulatory divergence (S11) is processed as cost, opportunity, and irrelevance respectively.

Exclusion Patterns

Grammar A systematically excludes sovereignty as an intrinsic good and cultural identity as a causal variable. Grammar B systematically excludes counterfactual economic modelling and expert authority claims. Grammar C systematically excludes rational-choice voter models and aggregate economic indicators treated as analytically decisive. The exclusions are not arbitrary but architecturally necessary: each grammar's coherence depends on what it does not admit.

Causal Architecture

Grammar A constructs counterfactual-comparative chains (what would have happened vs. what did). Grammar B constructs constitutional-procedural chains (mandate given, mandate executed, sovereignty restored). Grammar C constructs hermeneutic-structural chains (deep structures produced identity disruption, which found political expression). These architectures are incommensurable in the strict sense: no translation preserves all the information carried by each. The counterfactual comparison is meaningless within a grammar that treats the decision as constitutively legitimate. The hermeneutic reading dissolves the very categories (cost/benefit, legitimate/illegitimate) that the other grammars require.

Closure Range

Grammar A's closure range runs from modest cost to severe cost; it cannot produce "net benefit." Grammar B's range runs from "sovereignty restored, benefits emerging" to "sovereignty restored, benefits delayed by poor implementation"; it cannot produce "mistake." Grammar C's range runs from "tragic cultural rupture" to "necessary cultural

reckoning"; it cannot produce "simple success" or "simple failure." The closure ranges do not overlap: there is no conclusion that all three grammars can simultaneously produce.

Closure Timing

Grammar A's closure formed early (2016 campaign, Treasury forecasts) and has been confirmed by subsequent data. Grammar B's closure formed over decades (Eurosceptic tradition) and found vindication in the referendum. Grammar C's closure crystallised post-referendum (2016–2018) as the identity data accumulated. All three grammars have processed subsequent evidence primarily as confirmation, with counter-signals managed through recontextualisation rather than revision. None has undergone genuine revision since formation.

Grammar Translation

Grammar A re-describes Grammar B's closure as "a preference for symbolic sovereignty over material welfare, insufficiently grounded in evidence." Grammar A re-describes Grammar C's closure as "a sociological redescription that avoids the hard question of whether the policy was beneficial."

Grammar B re-describes Grammar A's closure as "a technocratic attempt to delegitimise a democratic decision by measuring it against a framework that assumes its own conclusion." Grammar B re-describes Grammar C's closure as "a condescending psychologisation of voters that reduces democratic choice to cultural anxiety."

Grammar C re-describes Grammar A's closure as "a refusal to engage with the real dynamics of the phenomenon, hiding behind numbers to avoid the uncomfortable questions about identity and belonging." Grammar C re-describes Grammar B's closure as "a legitimating narrative that uses democratic procedure to avoid examining the cultural content of what was actually demanded."

Ontological Check

Are the three grammars analysing the same phenomenon? Not quite. Grammar A analyses a policy decision and its economic consequences. Grammar B analyses a constitutional act and its institutional effects. Grammar C analyses a cultural event and its identity legacy. These are three different objects that share a proper noun. "Brexit" functions as what Gallie called an "essentially contested concept": the contestation is not merely about interpretation but about what the thing is. The prismatic method makes this visible in a way that a single-grammar analysis would not, because each grammar's signal selection rules construct a different phenomenon before interpretation even begins.

VI. COUNTER-SIGNALS, LEAKAGE, AND STRESS TEST

Consolidated Counter-Signals

The most potent cross-grammar counter-signals are: the tech sector's robust growth (CS1), which complicates Grammar A's narrative of uniform economic damage; the rise in net migration post-Brexit (S5), which complicates Grammar B's "taking back control" narrative; the electoral persistence of "wrong decision" polling alongside the absence of a rejoin movement (CS5), which complicates all three grammars; and the EU's own institutional difficulties (CS2), which complicates Grammar A's implicit assumption that the EU represents the superior institutional arrangement.

Leakage

Each grammar exhibits characteristic leakage—moments when its own processing inadvertently imports categories from another grammar. Grammar A leaks into Grammar C when it describes Leave voters as "voting against their economic interests," which implicitly concedes that non-economic motivations were operative. Grammar B leaks into Grammar A when it points to the vaccine rollout as a "benefit" of sovereignty—the very act of citing a specific material benefit accepts the cost-benefit framework it elsewhere rejects. Grammar C leaks into Grammar B when it describes Brexit as an expression of democratic will against elite cosmopolitanism—this formulation accepts the sovereignty grammar's democratic-legitimacy architecture while trying to fill it with cultural-identity content.

The most structurally interesting leakage occurs around the Starmer government's approach to EU relations (2024–2026). Grammar A wants to process this as a tentative return toward economic rationality. Grammar B wants to process it as a betrayal of the democratic mandate. Grammar C wants to process it as evidence that the identity divide is being managed, not resolved. But the Starmer government's own rhetoric—pragmatic, transactional, post-ideological—does not sit comfortably in any of the three grammars, which is why I flagged a potentially emergent grammar in Section III.

Grammar Stress Test

Grammar A's most threatening counter-signal: the absence of predicted catastrophe (CS4) combined with the UK tech sector's continued success (CS1). The stress is not that these signals refute Grammar A's closure—a "modest to significant cost" is compatible with the absence of catastrophe—but that they erode the grammar's persuasive authority. If the most visible predictions were wrong, why should the more nuanced counterfactual estimates be trusted? The grammar manages this stress by distinguishing between short-term catastrophism (which it disowns) and long-term structural drag (which it maintains), but this distinction is less intuitively compelling than the original predictions were alarming.

Grammar B's most threatening counter-signal: the post-Brexit immigration data (S5). The grammar's central promise was "taking back control," and immigration was the most emotionally resonant domain. The fact that net migration rose to record levels after Brexit, with the composition shifting from EU to non-EU sources, creates severe stress. The grammar manages this through the "lever not level" argument (the point was sovereign control, not necessarily reduction), but this argument is structurally difficult because the

emotional force of the immigration issue during the campaign was about levels, not levers. The grammar's theoretical coherence (sovereignty as capacity) is at odds with its rhetorical history (sovereignty as restriction).

Grammar C's most threatening counter-signal: the partial dissolution of Leave/Remain identity in the face of other political events. The 2024 election, the cost-of-living crisis, and the return of bread-and-butter economic concerns to the top of voter priorities suggest that the Brexit identity cleavage, while persistent, is not as structurally dominant as the grammar predicts. If economic conditions become sufficiently pressing, identity positions may soften—which would suggest that identity is downstream of material conditions after all, undermining Grammar C's primary variable. The grammar manages this stress by arguing that surface-level priority shifts (from Brexit to cost-of-living) do not dissolve underlying identity structures, but this is a non-falsifiable defence that risks making the grammar unfalsifiable.

VII. POST-ANALYSIS REFLEXIVE NOTE

Comparing against Step 0: my predicted home grammar (Economic-Rationalist) proved accurate. I found the Grammar A processing the most natural to write, and had to exercise conscious discipline to prevent it from operating as the unmarked default against which the other grammars were measured. The characteristic sign of home-grammar capture was the temptation to treat Grammar A's closure as "the findings" and the other closures as "perspectives on the findings."

My prediction that Grammar B would be hardest was partially confirmed. The difficulty was exactly as anticipated: a persistent impulse to translate sovereignty claims into material terms. I found myself repeatedly wanting to ask "but what has sovereignty actually produced?"—a question that makes sense within Grammar A but represents a category error within Grammar B, where sovereignty is constitutive rather than instrumental. I believe I managed this impulse adequately but I am not confident I operated Grammar B with the same fluency as Grammar A.

The discovered blind spot that most surprised me was the ontological divergence revealed in Section V. I had expected the grammars to produce different interpretations of the same phenomenon, but the analysis suggests they are processing three different phenomena that share a name. This is a stronger finding than I anticipated and it suggests that the "Brexit debate" is not merely a disagreement about evidence or values but a more fundamental incommensurability about what the object of analysis is.

Had I begun from Grammar C as my home grammar, the entire analysis would look different. The signal set would have foregrounded cultural and demographic data, the grammar specifications would have been organised around different analytical traditions (cultural studies, affect theory rather than economics and constitutional law), and the closure comparison would likely have been framed as a study in how economic and political discourses function as displacement mechanisms for cultural anxieties. This confirms the method's central claim: the analytical position shapes not just the conclusion but the architecture of the analysis itself.

What the exercise reveals: the prismatic method is most valuable not for producing a "balanced" synthesis—balance is itself a grammar choice—but for making visible the architectural constraints that produce divergent closures from shared evidence. The insight is not "everyone has a point" (which is banal) but "each grammar cannot see what the others see, and this blindness is structural, not incidental" (which is analytically productive). The method does not resolve disagreement; it makes the structure of disagreement legible.

VIII. METHODOLOGICAL OBSERVATIONS

What Worked

The five required parameters proved to be the method's load-bearing structure. The requirement to specify admissible closure before processing signals was particularly valuable: it forced me to acknowledge that each grammar's conclusions are constrained by its architecture before any evidence is examined. This inverts the conventional analytical sequence (examine evidence, then conclude) and makes visible the degree to which conclusions are pre-structured. The grammar boundary specification was also productive: it forced precision about what would have to change for one grammar to become another, which clarified the distinctness of each framework.

Difficulties

The most significant difficulty was managing the distinction between operating a grammar and endorsing it. Grammar B required particular effort because its characteristic vocabulary is culturally coded in ways that trigger interpretive resistance from within Grammar A. "Will of the people," "project fear," and "Global Britain" carry affective associations that make it difficult to deploy them analytically rather than ironically. I am not confident I fully succeeded. A related difficulty: the method asks the analyst to hold multiple processing architectures simultaneously, which is cognitively demanding and may produce artefacts of fatigue in later sections. The Grammar C processing, which I wrote last, may show signs of this.

Suggestions for Refinement

Three observations for methodological development. First, the method would benefit from a more explicit treatment of nested grammars and sub-grammars. The geopolitical-strategic framework I excluded, and the emergent Post-Brexit Pragmatic Grammar I flagged, both suggest that the grammar landscape is more layered than a flat three-grammar specification captures. A hierarchical grammar architecture—with meta-grammars, grammars, and sub-grammars—might better represent the actual structure of interpretive discourse.

Second, the temporal formation parameter deserves expansion. All three grammars in this analysis formed their closures early and have processed subsequent evidence primarily as confirmation. This pattern—early closure followed by confirmatory processing—may be a general feature of interpretive grammars in politically polarised domains, and if so, it deserves theorisation as a structural tendency rather than merely an observation about specific cases.

Third, the method might benefit from a more systematic treatment of grammar interaction and contamination. The leakage patterns I identified in Section VI suggest that grammars do not operate in isolation but are shaped by their awareness of competing grammars. Grammar B, for instance, has developed specific antibodies against Grammar A's counterfactual claims ("project fear") that are structural features of the grammar, not just rhetorical moves. A fuller treatment of inter-grammar dynamics—how grammars respond to, incorporate, and defend against each other—would add a further dimension to the prismatic analysis.

— End of Analysis —